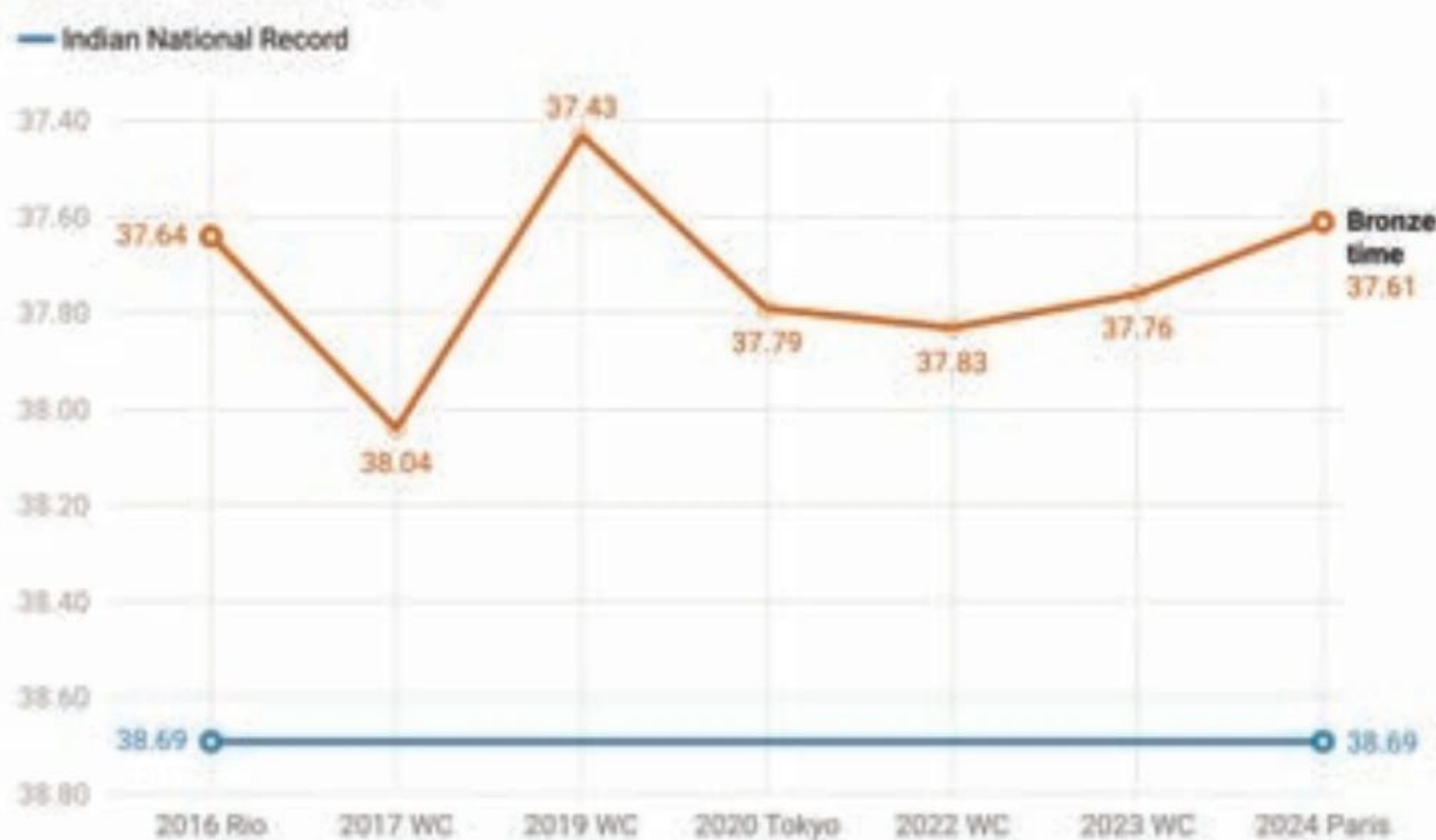
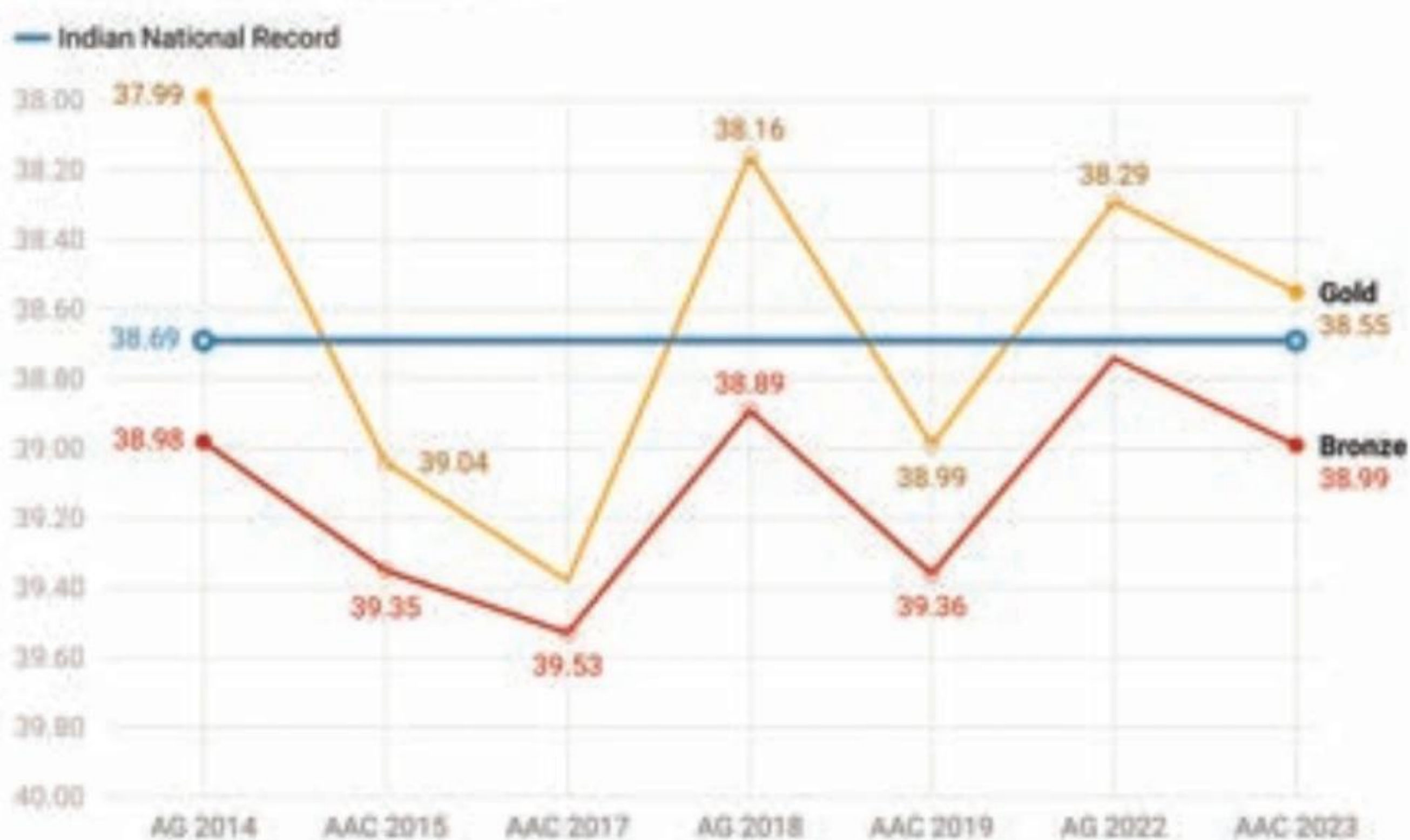


Bronze medal-winning time for 4x100m relay in global events from 2016



Gold and Bronze medal-winning time for 4x100m relay in Asian events from 2014



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Yet Hillier believes India can break the 38-second barrier even without a sub-10 runner.

"To estimate a relay time, you add the four individual 100m times and subtract between 2.1 and 3.0 seconds. A 2.4-second differential is good; 3.2 is exceptional. Right now, our team has a 2.4-second differential. In the 2010 national record (38.89), it was 2.81.

"I had predicted 38.62 even with poor exchanges. So, the 38.69 they ran suggests the exchanges weren't great. With excellent exchanges, they could run 37.82. If they matched the exchange efficiency of the 2010 team, they'd be at 38.2."

Apart from striving to meet their coach's standards, the Indian relay team is also chasing history. India's last medal in the men's 4x100m relay at the Asian Athletics Championships came in 1979. To find a medal at the Asian Games itself, you have to go even further back, to 1970.

That drought could end soon. The 38.69-second effort would have secured India a podium finish at every Asian Games and AAC over the past decade — and even a gold medal at three of the last seven AACs. Since 2024, only Japan, China, and South Korea have clocked faster relay times among Asian nations. Notably, Japan and China were Olympic finalists in Paris.

Still, Hillier (**left**) isn't interested in burdening his athletes with expectations.

"Of course we want to win a medal. But we can't go in expecting it. In athletics, the moment you start expecting, things often don't go to plan. We need to make it happen.

"The key is to stay focused. We can't let excitement get in the way. We have to get in and out of the exchange box at the right time."

But at the global level, the gap is wider. Indian sprinters would need to trim nearly a second off their collective timing to contend for a medal at the World Championships or the Olympics.

Their next big target is the World Athletics Championships in Tokyo, but the road is steep. India missed